

That, which, and extra information

Teaching guide

Show whether a relative clause identifies something or adds a detail.

Understand the distinction

A defining relative clause identifies the noun: The bike that has a red seat is mine. For things, that and which can both introduce defining clauses, though some style guides prefer that.

A non-defining clause adds extra information and uses commas: My bike, which has a red seat, is outside. Use which, not that, for this extra-information pattern. For people, who is often appropriate. Meaning decides whether the information is defining.

Compare the patterns

IDENTIFY

The report that arrived today is final.

This identifies which report.

ADD A DETAIL

The report, which arrived today, is final.

The report is already identified.

PEOPLE

The colleague who helped me is here.

Who refers to a person.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Choose for extra information: My laptop, ___ is new, works well.

2. Can which introduce a defining clause about a thing?

3. Add punctuation for extra information: Our office which opened in May is nearby.

Use it in your own life

Describe an object with one extra detail in a which clause.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. which

A non-defining clause uses which for things.

2. Yes, although some style guides prefer that.

Do not mark all defining uses of which as ungrammatical.

3. Our office, which opened in May, is nearby.

The commas mark the additional detail.

One possible response

My bag, which has a green label, is under the chair.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-12.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Describe an object with one extra detail in a which clause.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.